

Hard lessons

India's young players gained **valuable experience** at the Chennai WTA 250, where Indonesia's Janice Tjen lifted the title after a week of rain, resilience and promise.

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Watching a Tour-level tennis event in their own backyard was an annual tradition for the people of Chennai from 1997 to 2017.

Tales of the generational duel between Spaniards Carlos Moya and Rafael Nadal in 2008, or Stan Wawrinka wielding a cricket bat to hit a few balls into the crowd after his fourth title in 2016, are retold with pride and nostalgia. A women's tournament has rekindled hopes of reviving that tradition this decade.

Three years after the inaugural edition in 2022, when a capacity crowd at the SDAT Stadium witnessed Czech teenager Linda Fruhvirtova win her maiden Tour-level title, the WTA 250 event returned to the city last week. It coincided with the centenary year of the Tamil Nadu Tennis Association (TNTA).

The initial entry list featured French Open semifinalist Lois Boisson, former Wimbledon semifinalist Tatjana Maria, and quarterfinalist Lulu Sun, but their



Valiant effort: Shrivalli Bhamidipaty lost 7-5, 7-6(2) to Australian Kimberly Birrell in the round of 16. B.JOTHI RAMALINGAM

withdrawals due to injuries and scheduling conflicts meant that the final draw of 32 had Turkiye's Zeynep Sonmez (World No. 73) as the top seed. Paris Olympics silver medallist Donna Vekic (World No. 78) — who had endured a rough season — was the only high-profile name remaining.

Scope for improvement

India's top two players, Sahaja Yamalapalli (World No. 344) and Shrivalli Bhamidipaty (World No. 434), along with promising junior Maaya Rajeshwaran Revathi, were awarded wildcards. Later, Vaishnavi Adkar, another Indian, entered the main draw as a lucky loser. All four players made their Tour-level debuts.

The luck of the draw meant that 23-year-old Shrivalli and 16-year-old Maaya had to face each other in the opening round, ensuring a local player's presence in the second round. The teenager from Coimbatore was visibly nervous and could not reproduce the level she had displayed during her stunning run to the WTA 125 Mumbai Open semifinals in

February as a qualifier. Shrivalli won the contest 6-1, 6-4 to set up a meeting with seventh-seeded Australian Kimberly Birrell (World No. 117). On her 25th birthday, Sahaja battled for two hours to register a 6-4, 6-2 win over Indonesian lucky loser Priska Nugroho. Her reward was a second-round clash with Vekic, the third-seeded Croatian, who had defeated 20-year-old Vaishnavi 6-1, 6-2. Both Shrivalli and Sahaja fought valiantly in their round-of-16 defeats against experienced opponents ranked far above them. While Sahaja went down 6-2, 6-2 to Vekic, Shrivalli lost 7-5, 7-6(2) to Birrell.

Nirupama Sanjeev, the first Indian woman to win a Grand Slam match in the Open Era, had the perfect view of proceedings as a commentator during the tournament. She offered encouraging words and valuable advice for the current lot.

"They are able to match these top players ball for ball. I just want them to think about adding some variety to their game as well. These players are